

Meritocracy and Democracy: Indian Reservations and the Politics of Caste

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In the lead-up to independence, Indian statesmen grappled with how to address persistent social inequalities within an emerging democratic polity. The end of colonial rule promised equal citizenship in place of subjecthood. At the same time, there was general agreement in the Constituent Assembly that the disparities of caste and class demanded substantive redress. At the time, two points of debate emerged that have been remarkably resilient. The first was whether redress through caste quotas was itself discriminatory and a violation of the right to equality. Time became one means of reconciling equality and the need for "compensatory discrimination"; lawmakers proposed reserved seats for lower castes in educational institutions and in public-sector employment as a temporary departure from a liberal baseline of formal equality. Another means of reconciling the two was scope: to maintain the "rule" of equality, quotas were to remain applicable only to a minority of "backward" citizens. The second point of debate was around perpetuating caste as a form of social distinction by according it legal recognition. Caste classification was deemed necessary for "Scheduled Castes," those on the lowest rung of the caste ladder who suffered the stigma of untouchability. However, there was far less consensus on how to classify the intermediate castes. For these groups, lawmakers underscored the need to think of caste in relation to economic class in determining "backwardness" so that caste would remain tied to the "real" economy and, with modernization, wither away.

These concerns expressed ambivalence around acknowledging caste as a form of lived inequality that was irreducible to other forms of stratification. The tension between a governmental commitment to eliminating forms of inequality

rooted in ascriptive ties and the perception of caste as an outmoded category of social belonging with no place in a modern polity limited the scope of intervention. Despite the persistence of such concerns, however, the Indian legislature and courts over the past sixty years have moved definitively toward an embrace of quotas as a necessary mechanism of recompense and redistribution. Supreme Court judgments from the 1950s through the 2000s illuminate shifts from a more categorical stand in favor of formal equality toward an embrace of measures to bridge the gap between formal and substantive equality. But even as more and more ink was spilled in debating the appropriate limits to quotas and the caste versus class contours of social disadvantage, the inheritances that underwrote achievement slipped out of view. For the judiciary, the upper caste subject remained the ideal citizen defined by individual merit. By contrast, lower castes were marked by history and identity.

The invisibility of caste privilege was especially pronounced in the educational domain. Those who qualified for educational quotas on the basis of social disadvantages were identified within the “reserved category” through their caste affiliation, whereas those who did not qualify were simply classed under the “general category” of “merit-based” admissions. The absencing of caste from the postcolonial administrative classification of upper caste students marked a key transition in official parlance that came to intersect in critical ways with their self-fashioning as modern meritocratic subjects. This categorical distinction between the meritorious/casteless and the reserved/caste-based has profoundly shaped the debate around educational equality in India. It has allowed those who fall within the general category to argue that it is the system of reservations, and not the inheritances of caste, that undermines the democratic ideal of equal citizenship.

Sociologist Satish Deshpande has attributed the unmarking of upper castes to the logic of Indian constitutionalism. He maintains that the new constitution “constrained the victims of caste to demand justice as a caste-marked exception, while its beneficiaries were empowered to demand the perpetuation of their advantages as a casteless norm” (2012: 2). Deshpande turns to the first postcolonial anti-reservations case to prove his point. In 1951, two Tamil Brahmin petitioners claimed that their fundamental right to equality and nondiscrimination guaranteed by Article 15(1) of the Constitution was violated by caste quotas in medical and engineering colleges. The Madras High Court agreed and ruled in their favor. Deshpande (2013: 37) argues that the 1951 verdict offered upper castes a form of agency “based on the universal normative position of ‘castelessness.’ . . . Constitutionally and legally, caste was henceforth to be recognized only as a source of disadvantage or vulnerability, not as a source of privilege or advantage.” As such,

he continues, it “authored and disseminated a new kind of common sense where the very definition of caste was truncated and equated with the lower castes,” and upper castes came to be seen and to see themselves as “casteless.”

My work builds on Deshpande’s but adds a key component: the dialectic of upper caste claims to meritocracy and lower caste assertion. In part, this is in order to illuminate caste as the product of longer historical relationships and show how it has been reconfigured by democratic politics. But it is also to make the more general point that caste privilege does not seamlessly reproduce itself. The proliferation of rights discourses and politics, the extension of universal franchise, and the entry of new social groups into social and economic spaces previously monopolized by elites have posed real challenges to caste hierarchies. Upper caste strategies, such as the claim to merit, must therefore be seen as part of the effort to secure arenas of expertise and accumulation against lower caste advancement.

I also question Deshpande’s assumption that high castes believe themselves to be “casteless.” It is true that in the logic of legal judgments, the imagined future of castelessness is transposed on to the “general category.” Even after the courts turned in favor of reservations, caste continued to be explicitly marked mostly on one side of the equation, reinforcing the perception of upper castes as casteless moderns whose merit was the result of talent, not privilege. However, there is another side to this process which we see both in judicial and popular discourse: the marking of caste as culture, as natural aptitude, and as the very basis of merit. Upper castes did not just come to think of themselves as casteless. Rather, they began to mark caste affiliation differently and in ways that expressed understandings of both caste nature and democratic culture.

In my larger work, I examine this interplay between upper and lower caste claims, and between caste marking and unmarking, through a historical anthropology of Indian engineering education (see Subramanian 2019). My ethnographic focus is on the Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs), a set of elite engineering colleges that are both emblems of meritocracy and, until recently, spaces of caste exclusivity. Within the IIT system, I look more closely at one campus—IIT Madras located in Chennai, the capital city of the southeastern state of Tamilnadu. Tamilnadu is a particularly illuminating context in which to look at the making of upper caste meritocracy because of its long history of lower caste rights politics. The Non-Brahmin and Dravidian movements that swept the region from the 1910s profoundly reshaped the Tamil political and social milieu. These movements espoused the cause of “Dravidians,” a social category that, depending on its target of opposition, was variously coded as racial, caste-based, linguistic, or territorial. Tamilnadu is now known for its highly politicized lower caste majority, the

predominance of regional parties emerging out of Dravidianism, and far-reaching institutional reform through the implementation of caste quotas that brought more lower castes into professional fields of training.

Moreover, Dravidianism has complicated the naturalization of merit and the transformation of upper castes into casteless moderns. Here, as in other regions with strong traditions of lower caste rights, upper caste intellectual achievement is understood as a legacy of historical social inequalities requiring correctives. To put it differently, in Tamilnadu, upper castes, and Brahmins in particular, were marked *as castes* by the Dravidian movement. This marking of upper castes has produced a different politics around meritocracy. Rather than a claim to castelessness, upper castes engage in practices of self-marking and unmarking through which they make caste belonging consistent with merit. And they do so in reaction to lower caste assertion, and in contradistinction to the reserved category. In this sense, Tamilnadu is an important precedent in making the general category a putatively universal norm whose external limit is caste backwardness. With the expansion of lower caste rights politics across the subcontinent, this claim to merit as the non-reserved has become a more generalized phenomenon seen not just in legal challenges to reservations but in social movements such as the anti-reservations agitations of 1990 and 2006, as well as in more quotidian practices. By illuminating Tamilnadu as a precursor to these trends, my work calls into question castelessness as a stable structure of postcolonial, upper caste subjectivity. Instead, I ask how Tamilnadu might inform an analysis of upper casteness more broadly. When do upper castes claim merit on the basis of castelessness and when on the basis of caste?

The rest of the article addresses the production of upper casteness through the claim to merit as the non-reserved. It tracks this process at three scales: the regional, the national, and the transnational. I begin in the region and explore how the caste tensions generated by Dravidianism produced practices of distinction at IIT Madras. The next section expands out from the region to consider the impact on caste formation of reservations for intermediate castes, or “Other Backward Classes” (OBCs), introduced in 1990 and 2006. I show how the expansion of lower caste rights politics from south to north catalyzed a similar interplay of self-marking and unmarking through which upper casteness has been produced at a national scale. Finally, I follow these dynamics to the United States to argue that transnational mobility has serviced the retrenchment of caste privilege away from the ferment of lower caste rights politics.

Tamilnadu's approach to reservations has some distinguishing characteristics that speak to a longer regional history of caste formation and contestation. First, caste is understood to be a structuring principle of society and politics. Rather than moving toward an ideal of casteless meritocracy, governmental policy is aimed at fostering caste competition for resources. Second, reservations are understood as much through a logic of proportional representation as they are as redress for historical inequities. In this sense, the region is more in continuity with an earlier colonial model of representation that approached ascriptive collectives as the basic units of political society. Finally, Dravidian populism has meant the centrality of the political arena to resource allocation. Whenever the courts have pushed back against the expansion of regional quotas beyond the designated central government limit of 50 percent, popular pressure has won out. In all these ways, Tamilnadu has systematically disregarded the liberal norm of formal equality, making it a target of anti-reservations arguments.

The tensions between regional and central government approaches to reservations are evident in the sphere of engineering education. The Southeast was one of the first regions where caste quotas in education and employment were implemented in 1921. The reservations system has expanded steadily to the point where, now, most regional engineering colleges in Tamilnadu reserve up to 69 percent of their seats for those designated as lower castes. These measures have had considerable success at changing the caste composition of regional colleges from the days when Tamil Brahmins monopolized over 70 percent of seats (Fuller and Narasimhan 2008).

This was the context for the 1951 court case brought by the two Tamil Brahmins challenging reservations. Soon after, in 1959, IIT Madras was founded and came to play a critical role in suturing caste and merit. As a central government institution initially exempt from caste quotas, it has long been seen by its detractors as an upper caste stronghold where claims to intellectual superiority have strong caste overtones. IIT Madras is even sardonically referred to by some in the vernacular press as "Iyer Iyengar Technology" in reference to the two Tamil Brahmin subcastes. What is less considered in these popular discourses is how the institution operates as a critical site, not for the expression of an already existing group identity, but for the very constitution of Brahminness.

While there are various practices of distinction at IIT Madras, all of them produce correlations between caste, knowledge, and merit. Here, I elaborate on just one: the idea that upper caste knowledge is more mobile than lower caste

knowledge. This expectation that the “true” IITian should be a mobile subject does not arise from a generic, or recent, claim to cosmopolitanism. It reflects the worldview of an upper caste intelligentsia who were members of an internal, pan-Indian diaspora of civil servants and whose children form the core of the IITs. A shared history of education and employment has given these students a sense of themselves, not just as members of regional caste groupings, but as nationals who properly belong in national institutions. Within Tamilnadu, it is Brahmins—the caste who entered the modern professions in the greatest numbers—who have historically constituted the vast majority of this diaspora. As a result, they are over-represented in Central Board schools that cater to children of the national civil services. These schools explicitly state as one of their key missions, “to develop the spirit of national integration and create a sense of ‘Indianness’ among children.”¹ The notion of “Indianness” gestures to an identity that is supra-regional and supra-caste. But in the Tamil context, the Central Board maps quite explicitly onto Brahminness and has become the basis for claims to intellectual merit. The assumption that the Central Board curriculum produces “thinking students” who are better suited than students from the regional State Board schools to intellectual life in general and the IITs in particular was conveyed to me across a wide swath of interviews with teachers, administrators, and students. Person after person distinguished the Central Board’s “conceptual training” from the “rote learning” in the State Boards. It was this training, they argued, that made their students a natural fit, first for the IITs, and then for transnational careers.

Kartik, a 1990 Tamil Brahmin alumnus, talked to me about his educational trajectory. He had attended Central Board schools in the North before joining one in Chennai. Kartik described the school as a bubble within the city where the vast majority of his classmates were upper castes, and where getting into IIT Madras was the singular goal of his peers. Once he got to IIT Madras, Kartik told me, he felt truly at home. He talked about the comforting sense of homecoming he felt on entering the campus gates where he could stop de-Brahminizing his Tamil and slip back into the Brahmin vernacular spoken by his family. Kartik also spoke of an intimacy between Tamil Brahmin students and professors through the cultivation, not just of shared intellectual projects, but of a form of extended caste kinship expressed, for instance, in invitations to family functions.

But IIT Madras was not simply a site for Brahmin caste kinship within a “non-Brahmin” region. On campus, other Tamils who got in through the “general category” were assumed to be Brahmin. Bharathan, a 1995 Tamil alumnus from

1. From the Kendriya Vidyalaya Sangathan website: <http://kvsangathan.nic.in/Mission.aspx>.

a State Board school, narrated his own conscription into Brahminness. He was changing his clothes when his Tamil Brahmin roommate inquired into the whereabouts of his *poonal*, the sacred thread worn by male Brahmins. “When I told him that I don’t wear one, he paused and then asked, ‘Doesn’t your mother get upset?’ It never struck him that I was Backward Caste. In fact, I think he still assumes that I’m from a particularly liberal Brahmin family.”

Bharathan’s experience of his own illegibility speaks, not so much to the castelessness of the IITian but to his explicit marking, when it comes to Tamils, as Brahmin. This desire to erase difference is particularly telling in the context of Tamilnadu where a long history of reservations has meant that increasing numbers of lower castes do in fact inhabit the same institutional spaces as upper castes. Here, IIT Madras has uniquely serviced the need to once again differentiate upper from lower: just when caste status boundaries are blurring in the wider region, within the walls of the institution, it became imperative to mark the Tamil IITian as Brahmin and, in this way, to reinstate merit and its associated forms of mobility as indices of Brahminness.

In addition to mobility, other forms of embodied cultural capital also indexed Brahminness. The display of bodily neglect was one. Ratty T-shirts, jeans, and flip-flops signaled a Brahmin background in which the consumption of knowledge is prized above commodity consumption. These assumptions acquire a disciplining force. Palani, a lower caste student from Chennai who got in through the general category, told me how he made a point of switching out his shoes for flip-flops when he came back to campus after weekends at home. It was just easier than “standing out.” Not all lower caste students opted to pass for upper caste. But even those who laid claim to merit by pointing to their admission through the general category were legible only as exceptions.

These instances of misrecognition, sartorial code switching, and the exceptional status of lower caste students who got in on “merit” point to the nonfungibility of the general category. While ostensibly open to all, the *de facto* assumption when it came to Tamils was that it was populated only by Brahmins. Such instances of caste solidarity and misrecognition might suggest that the claim to merit at IIT Madras is only about the institutional production of Brahminness. While it is certainly the case that a regional history of caste formation has given merit a uniquely Brahminical inflection, other examples reveal a structure of feeling through which merit is increasingly mapped not simply onto Brahminness but onto an expanded category of upper casteness. Here, too, merit is articulated in opposition to lower caste assertion and rights, although now this dialectic is rescaled nationally and is evident across the IITs and other central government

institutions. We see this shift in response to two sets of national quotas implemented in 1990 and 2006.

National

Before 1990, the only quotas that applied to central government education and employment were the 1973 central government quotas of 15 percent for Scheduled Castes and 7 percent for Scheduled Tribes, the two groups at the lowest rung of the administrative typology of backwardness. This situation changed in 1990 when then prime minister Vishwanath P. Singh announced that his government had accepted the recommendations of the Mandal Commission of Inquiry, a body constituted to look into the causes of social and educational backwardness, and would move forward with implementing 27 percent reservation for “Other Backward Classes” (OBCs)—groups occupying the intermediate rungs of the caste hierarchy—in central government employment. “Mandal,” the popular shorthand for the 27 percent OBC reservation, was part of a sea change in North Indian politics precipitated by the political mobilization and consolidation of lower castes (Jaffrelot 2003). This new politics lent the OBC category the same charge in the North that Dravidian previously had in the South.

The implementation of Mandal ignited a firestorm. Upper caste students took to the streets, staging sit-ins, blocking roads, and masquerading as vendors, sweepers, and shoe shiners in a graphic depiction of their future reduction to lower caste labor. At the same time, one of the accusations leveled against Mandal was that it was responsible for the spread of casteism, even of caste consciousness. In accusing Mandal of fomenting casteism, its detractors rendered it a regressively illiberal violation of the ideal of equality. They also faulted it for favoring “vote bank politics” over meritocracy. Through these performative and rhetorical maneuvers, casteless merit was paradoxically produced as an upper caste virtue.

What the Mandal Commission did, then, was extend the southern dialectic of lower caste claims to rights and upper caste claims to merit to the North. The 1990s OBC reservations also catalyzed new lines of division and precipitated more explicit claims to merit on the basis of upper casteness. Earlier, the non-reserved was treated as an unmarked collective that was tacitly assumed to be upper caste. With the expansion of reservations under Mandal, the general category became more explicitly marked as upper caste. The working assumption that anyone who could qualify for reservations did so produced a far more strident, defensive upper caste politics that put the categories of “general” and “reserved” into national circulation as shared referents of consolidated caste difference.

Mandal did not make much of an impact on the IITs. By the 1990s, the majority of IIT alumni went abroad or into private-sector jobs. As a result, they did not react as strongly to the implementation of quotas in public-sector employment. The 2006 reservations were a different story. In 2006, the Supreme Court ordered the implementation of the second part of the Mandal Commission's recommendations: 27 percent reservation for OBCs in all central government educational institutions, including the IITs. This quota brought the percentage of reserved seats at the IITs to forty-nine.

"Mandal II," as it came to be known, further entrenched the opposition between "general" and "reserved" as commonsensical and widely shared categories through which the Indian public understood caste difference. There are innumerable instances of news articles, films, and jokes that reinforced an upper caste common sense. One joke that I take from Satish Deshpande's retelling went something like this: "India decides to send a space exploration team to the moon. Feverish negotiations begin immediately on the composition of the team, and after much haggling it is decided to include nine OBCs, six SCs, three STs, and, if there is any place left, two astronauts." We see here the distinction between the caste-based and the meritorious. The OBCs, SCs, and STs, defined purely by their caste markers, are assumed to be utterly unqualified for professional positions and yet monopolize them because of political machinations. This arrangement sells short those who are the only ones actually qualified for the job. On one side is caste and politics, on the other, accomplished individuals. What remains unstated but assumed are the upper caste identities of the "astronauts." Through such expressions of anti-reservations discourse emerged an upside-down world where stigmatization and exclusion are the plight of upper castes and reservations are a corruption of pre-existing norms of equality, fairness, and justice. Despite the rhetorical leveraging of democratic equality, what was unmistakable in the opposition to reservations was the outrage at the disruption of a natural order in which upper caste dominance was assumed to be a by-product of talent and desert. Anti-reservation politics expressed a deep sense of injustice in the face of thwarted expectations and reinforced the notion that only upper castes are truly meritocratic subjects.

At IIT Madras, Mandal II unsettled assumptions about the campus's upper caste majority that had underwritten previous expressions of meritocracy and intensified the need to distinguish the "true" IITian from the imposter. The expansion of the reserved category to nearly half the student body generated an everyday diagnostics of caste through which everything from dress to facility with English and performance in classes came to be scrutinized for evidence of quota status.

The impact of heightened caste tensions has been made evident in the spate of suicides and attempted suicides by Dalit students across the IITs and other central government campuses.

While in some ways the expansion of the reserved category has increased everyday hostilities at IIT Madras, it has also undercut previous forms of upper caste hegemony. The increase in numbers of lower caste students gaining admissions through the quota has provided security and solidarity, allowing them to claim reservations as a legitimate right. This is evident, for instance, in new student organizations and events that espouse Left and Dravidianist sympathies and advance open criticisms of the upper caste underpinnings of meritocracy. In this way, the gulf separating IIT Madras from its regional milieu has narrowed in terms of demographic makeup and political outlook.

With the 2006 quota, IIT Madras and other central government educational institutions have ceased to be bastions of upper caste hegemony. But now, the private sector serves this purpose. Satish, a 2015 alumnus who was a beneficiary of the 2006 quota, told me that private-sector job recruitment has become a veritable minefield with recruiters actively probing for information about quota status. This usually happened through questions about a candidate's rank on the IIT entrance examination, which offers clues about the person's admissions category. Even if one did not internalize the stigmatization of the reserved, Satish pointed out, trying to pass as non-reserved had become a necessary skill in navigating a treacherous private-sector landscape where achievement is seen as natural for some and impossible for others.

Transnational

In addition to domestic private-sector employment, transnational mobility has been another mechanism for securing caste entitlements that have eroded with the expansion of reservations. This is especially the case in the United States where the professional and financial successes of IITians have been facilitated by the resurgence of ascriptive understandings of intellect and skill in the "knowledge economy." Outside India, caste is far less legible. Instead, university admissions committees and corporate recruiters resort to broad-brush racial typologies in explaining the IITian's intellect. For their part, the diaspora of IIT alumni capitalizes on the racial mystique around Indian technical genius to shore up their status as casteless global moderns. Even while they leverage stereotypes of the "technological Indian" (Bassett 2016), IIT alumni networks have been very active in protecting the brand value and exceptional standing of their own alma maters. Older

alumni are hugely influential in inducting newer ones into university campuses and entrepreneurial ventures. Others have promoted the IITs through the media. For instance, in a 2003 interview on the CBS news show *60 Minutes*, Vinod Khosla, IIT alumnus and cofounder of Sun Microsystems, argued that Fortune 500 headhunters favor IITians over almost anybody else. As he put it, “If you’re a WASP walking in for a job, you wouldn’t have as much pre-assigned credibility as you do if you’re an engineer from IIT” (quoted in Leung 2003).

This pattern of racialization for the market is evident in the role of US-based IIT alumni in facilitating Indian entrepreneurship. The Indus Entrepreneurs, an organization started by alumni in Silicon Valley in 1992, aims at consolidating transnational networks of South Asian capital. It currently boasts a membership of more than thirteen thousand, and its list of mentors includes the most recognized Indian names in the corporate sector. In conversations with both senior mentors and junior members of the organization, it became obvious that the entrepreneurial ambitions of IITians are the most actively cultivated. When a group of IITians brings forward a proposal, they are almost guaranteed seed funding. In the United States, these expressions of transnational institutional kinship have both underwritten the commodity value of an IIT education and enhanced the racial mystique around the IITian’s intellect. When American understandings of the IITian’s racial talent travel back to India, they reinforce claims to caste exceptionalism.

That caste distinction is at the heart of these forms of transnational institutional kinship is evident in the political work of diasporic IITians. In 2006, as the extension of OBC quotas to the IITs was being debated in the Indian parliament, alumni in Silicon Valley organized under the banner “Indians for Equality” and took to the streets. At one such protest, an IIT alumnus argued to an Indian reporter that the Indian government should “leave the IITs alone. . . . It is because of us that the West has recognized the worth of India. . . . Remember, brand India is brand IIT” (Chadha 2006). This warning expresses in the clearest possible terms the equation between caste belonging, institutional status, and market value. With the threat of lower caste encroachment, the market value of “brand IIT” is more explicitly equated with upper casteness and the relationship of caste privilege to capital accumulation laid bare. Moreover, with the invocation of the West as audience, IITians claim to be shoring up the value of “brand India” itself through the protection of upper casteness.

Significantly, many of the same diasporic alumni who virulently oppose reservations in India support diversity policies in the United States. Several contrasted the representative logic that underpins diversity from the redistributive impulse of reservations. The principle of diversity, they argued, was consistent with meri-

ocracy because it recognized and rewarded individual talent. By contrast, quotas corrupted both merit and democracy by creating interest groups based solely on identity to which the state was captive. As evidence of these claims, they juxtaposed the “mediocrity” of Indian education with the “excellence” of American education, while taking care to set the IITs apart as an exception to the Indian norm. As one 1978 alumnus put it, “In India, reservations benefit undeserving people and makes everyone mediocre. In the US people excel because they are rewarded and not punished for their talent.”

In this capsule statement, we see the divergent visions of democracy that make reservations such a political lightning rod: the first rests on a formal definition of equality that attributes social hierarchies to the natural aptitudes of individuals and groups; the second presupposes the existence of historically accumulated privileges and disadvantages and the need for compensatory measures to level opportunity. Those who most vocally oppose reservations argue that it undercuts the principle of equality and is antithetical to merit. But there are different understandings of equality at stake here, and they have steadily diverged over the course of India’s postindependence history. The strident claim to merit as an upper caste virtue and discrediting of redress as “vote bank politics” is evidence of increasingly incommensurate visions of the Indian future.

Conclusion

Reservations disrupted the tacit role of ascription by explicitly naming caste as a factor in educational achievement. In setting aside a percentage of seats for lower caste groups, reservations policy sought to correct for historically sedimented disadvantages. Initially, when the quota was small, the upper caste claim to be representative of the meritocratic norm was in many respects reinforced. By marking only its beneficiaries as caste subjects, reservations policy underwrote the status of upper castes as emblematic of meritocracy. Early on, upper castes expressed their claim to meritocracy in universalistic terms that did not require an explicit defense of caste entitlement. Only Tamil Brahmins shaped by a regional politics of caste marking equated merit explicitly with caste culture. However, this changed with the steady expansion of quotas in tandem with the growth in lower caste rights politics. With the implementation of Mandal I and II, upper caste claims to meritocracy were no longer universalistic; they became explicitly identitarian in nature and expressed a consolidated form of upper casteness.

In postindependence India, new patterns of caste stratification and consolidation have emerged through the very process of democratic transformation. Rather

than the gradual erosion of caste, what we are seeing is the leveraging of merit by upper castes to secure new arenas of expertise and accumulation against lower caste rights. Upper caste claims have been strengthened by the resurgence within the late twentieth-century knowledge economy of ascriptive understandings of skill and intelligence. Rather than just subaltern identitarianism, then, the leveraging of caste must also be seen as an upper caste politics that attempts to forestall democratic progress and derives its legitimacy from a larger global politics of ascription.

We see the dialectics of competing caste claims in the shifting spaces of upper caste retrenchment. First, Tamilnadu's Brahmins turned to central government education and employment as a refuge from Dravidianist politics. With Mandal I and II, these central government spaces ceased to play this role, leading upper castes to move increasingly into the domestic private sector and abroad. Of course, one could argue that upper castes "won" in the end because they were able to secure these spaces of accumulation. However, the upper caste flight from the state into the domain of capital is not simply an offensive strategy that preemptively secures their power and seamlessly reproduces structures of inequality. Rather, it is indicative of an ongoing war of maneuver (Gramsci 1971: 291) that propels the dynamics of the democratic process.

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